



EAM310 · WEEK 3 · JULY 25, 2026

Pulse Diagnosis Pre-Lecture Analysis Sheet

The 28 Pulse Qualities

FCM Chapter 25 · CAM Chapter 13
Components of a Normal Pulse · 28 Classical Pulse Qualities

Quiz 2 — July 24, 2026 (Week 2 material)

TCM for Ballroom Dancers | Dance Medicine Specialty

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PRE-LECTURE READING (DUE BEFORE JUL 25)

FCM Chapter 25 — Maciocia

- The Normal Pulse (p.157 of Ch.25)
- 28 pulse qualities — full descriptions
- Pulse qualities grouped by category
- Clinical significance of each quality

CAM Chapter 13 — Cheng Xinnong

- Normal pulse description
- 28 pathological pulse types
- Pulse-taking method review
- Yin/Yang groupings of pulses

THE NORMAL (NORMAL) PULSE — 平脈 Píng Mài

Four Characteristics (Maciocia FCM Ch.25)

Quality	Description
Rate	4–5 beats/respiration (72–80 bpm)
Depth	Not too superficial, not too deep — felt at middle level
Strength	Forceful but not excessive; soft but not empty
Rhythm	Regular — no skipped or irregular beats

Factors That Modify Normal Pulse

Factor	Normal Variation
Season	Spring: slightly wiry · Summer: flooding · Autumn: floating · Winter: deep
Age	Children: faster · Elderly: deeper, weaker
Gender	Women: slightly softer, right slightly larger
Body type	Tall: slower · Short: faster · Thin: more superficial · Heavy: deeper
Exercise	Faster, fuller — returns to normal at rest
Emotion	Fear → rapid · Anger → wiry · Grief → thin
Meals	Slippery/fuller after eating
Pregnancy	Slippery, especially in Cun

Three Essential Qualities (CAM 13)

有胃 · 有神 · 有根

- **Yǒu Wèi** — Has Stomach Qi: flowing, gentle, harmonious
- **Yǒu Shén** — Has Spirit: strong, rhythmical, responsive
- **Yǒu Gēn** — Has Root: felt at deep level in Chi position; Kidney Qi

PULSE POSITIONS — REVIEW 寸關尺

Position	Cun 寸 (distal)	Guan 關 (middle)	Chi 尺 (proximal)
Left Hand Heart side	Heart / Small Intestine also: chest, Pericardium	Liver / Gallbladder	Kidney (Yin) / Bladder also: Lower Jiao (L)
Right Hand Lung side	Lung / Large Intestine also: chest	Spleen / Stomach	Kidney (Yang) / Bladder also: Lower Jiao (R)

A floating pulse ≠ always Exterior pattern. In a patient with Yin deficiency (night sweats, five-palm heat, malar flush), a floating and empty pulse = **Empty Heat / Yin Def.** Context is everything.

MNEMONIC: REMEMBER THE 7 GROUPS**Floating · Sinking · Rate · Strength · Width · Rhythm · Other Special**

Group them by what you're feeling first — then identify the specific quality within that group

Pulse Name (CN)	Qualities / How to Feel It	Clinical Indication	Group / Notes
► FLOATING GROUP (浮 fú) — felt at superficial level			
Floating 浮 Fú	Felt easily at superficial level; weakens on pressure	Exterior patterns; also Yin def (floating + empty)	↑ Depth
Hollow 芤 Kōu	Floating, large, soft — feels hollow in middle like a scallion stalk	Loss of Blood or fluids (heavy bleeding, profuse sweat)	↑ Depth + hollow center
Leather 革 Gé	Floating, taut, large, hollow — like a drum; firm on outside, empty inside	Loss of Jing/Blood, uterine bleeding, seminal emission	↑ Depth + hard surface
► SINKING GROUP (沉 chén) — felt only at deep level			
Deep 沉 Chén	Only felt with heavy pressure at bone level	Interior patterns; Qi stagnation, pain, Water retention	↓ Depth
Firm 牢 Láo	Deep, wiry, and forceful; remains hard under pressure	Accumulation of Cold, abdominal masses	↓ Depth + hard
Hidden 伏 Fú	Even deeper than Deep — felt only at bone; requires very heavy pressure	Severe interior Cold, fainting, extreme pain	↓ Depth extremis
► RATE GROUP — beats per respiration cycle			
Rapid 數 Shuò	>5 beats/resp (>90 bpm); fast throughout	Heat (Full or Empty); also extreme exhaustion of Qi	↑ Rate
Slow 遲 Chí	<4 beats/resp (<60 bpm)	Cold (Full or Empty); Yang deficiency	↓ Rate
Racing 疾 Jí	Extremely rapid (>7 beats/resp, >120 bpm)	Extreme Heat consuming Yin; dying Yang floating upward	↑ ↑ Rate extremis
Moderate 緩 Huǎn	4 beats/resp; slightly slower than normal; even, relaxed	Normal (if regular); Dampness; Spleen Qi def (if weak)	Normal/Damp
► STRENGTH GROUP — force / amplitude			
Full / Replete 實 Shí	Large, forceful at all three levels; does not weaken on pressure	Excess patterns; Full Heat; excess Fire	↑ Force
Empty / Deficient 虛 Xū	Soft, weak at all three levels; weakens further on pressure	Deficiency patterns; Qi/ Blood def	↓ Force
Weak 弱 Ruò	Deep, soft, fine/thin; only felt at deep level with light touch	Qi and Blood deficiency; Yang deficiency	↓ Force + deep

Pulse Name (CN)	Qualities / How to Feel It	Clinical Indication	Group / Notes
Frail / Minute 微 Wēi	Extremely thin, soft, barely perceptible; nearly absent	Severe Qi, Yang, and Blood deficiency; collapse	↓↓ Force extremis
► WIDTH / SHAPE GROUP			
Wiry / String-like 弦 Xián	Taut, tense, like pressing a violin string; long	Liver/GB patterns; pain; Phlegm; Damp; old age (normal)	Taut/Wiry
Slippery 滑 Huá	Smooth, flowing, like pearls rolling on a dish; fuller	Phlegm/Damp; Heat; pregnancy (normal); after meals (normal)	Smooth flow
Choppy / Rough 澀 Sè	Uneven, rough, hesitant, like scraping bamboo with a knife	Blood stasis; Blood/Fluid def; Jing deficiency	Rough/Uneven
Flooding / Surging 洪 Hóng	Large, forceful, rises like a wave, fades; felt widely	Excess Heat; Summer Heat; after exertion (normal)	Large + forceful
Thin / Fine 細 Xì	Thin like a thread; clearly perceptible; not weak	Blood def; Yin def; Damp (if slippery+thin)	Narrow width
Soggy / Soft 濡 Rú	Floating, thin, and soft; disappears on pressure	Dampness; Blood deficiency; Summer Damp	Float+thin+soft
Long 長 Cháng	Extends beyond the three positions; longer than normal	Excess patterns; Liver Fire; Full conditions	↑ Length
Short 短 Duǎn	Does not reach both ends; only felt in one position	Qi deficiency or stagnation; stagnation more common	↓ Length
► RHYTHM / REGULARITY GROUP			
Intermittent / Knotted 結 Jié	Slow, irregular; occasional missed beats; no fixed interval	Qi stagnation, Blood stasis; Phlegm; Cold; chronic conditions	Slow + irregular
Hurried / Swift 促 Cù	Rapid, irregular; occasional missed beats; no fixed interval	Excess Heat; Qi, Blood, Phlegm, Food stagnation	Rapid + irregular
Regularly Intermittent 代 Dài	Slow, misses beat at regular intervals; fixed interval	Organ Qi declining; serious Heart condition; pain; fright	Slow + regular gaps
► COMPOSITE PULSES (combinations of basic qualities)			
Overflowing 大 Dà	Wide, large; like Flooding but without wave force	Full Heat; early febrile disease	Large width
Tight / Tense 緊 Jǐn	Like a taut cord; feels like a twisted rope; more tense than wiry	Cold (Interior or Exterior); pain; retained food	Taut + twisting

MACIOCIA'S GROUPINGS — FCM Ch.25

EXTERIOR / INTERIOR

- **Exterior:** Floating, Tight (Cold), Rapid (Wind-Heat)
- **Interior:** Deep, Wiry, Slippery, Choppy, Full

DEFICIENCY / EXCESS

- **Def:** Empty, Thin, Weak, Frail, Choppy, Soggy
- **Excess:** Full, Wiry, Slippery, Flooding, Rapid

QI / BLOOD DEFICIENCY

- **Qi Def:** Empty, Weak, Frail
- **Blood Def:** Thin, Choppy, Weak

COLD / HEAT

- **Cold:** Slow, Tight, Deep, Firm
- **Heat:** Rapid, Flooding, Full, Slippery

PHLEGM / BLOOD STASIS

- **Phlegm/Damp:** Slippery, Soft, Wiry
- **Blood Stasis:** Choppy, Wiry, Firm

LIVER / KIDNEY

- **Liver:** Wiry (especially Left Guan)
- **Kidney Def:** Deep + weak at Chi

EASILY CONFUSED PULSE PAIRS — TEST HIGH-YIELD

Pair	Pulse A	Pulse B	Key Differentiator
Floating vs Hollow	Floating: weakens with pressure; not hollow	Hollow: floating but has hollow center (scallion)	Press in center — Hollow feels empty
Slippery vs Flooding	Slippery: smooth rolling; normal width	Flooding: large wave, forceful rise + fade	Flooding is LARGE; Slippery is smooth but not necessarily large
Wiry vs Tight	Wiry: taut like a violin string	Tight: taut like a twisted rope; more forceful, vibrating	Tight has a twisting/vibrating quality; Wiry is simply taut
Thin vs Soggy	Thin: thread-like but firm and perceptible at any depth	Soggy: floating, thin, AND soft — disappears under pressure	Soggy is floating + soft; Thin is just narrow
Choppy vs Intermittent	Choppy: rough texture; uneven force; no missing beats	Intermittent (Knotted): beats are actually MISSING (irregular)	Choppy = texture; Knotted/Hurried = missing beats
Knotted vs Hurried vs Reg. Intermittent	Knotted 結: slow + irregular skips	Hurried 促: rapid + irregular skips	Regularly Intermittent 代: slow + REGULAR fixed-interval skips = worst prognosis
Empty vs Weak vs Frail	Empty 虛: soft + weak at all levels	Weak 弱: deep + fine + soft	Frail 微: barely perceptible; most severe deficiency

PRE-LECTURE REFLECTION QUESTIONS

THINK ABOUT THESE BEFORE CLASS FRIDAY

1. What are the three essential qualities of a normal pulse (胃神根)? Describe each in your own words.
2. How would you differentiate a Floating Empty pulse (Yin def) from a Floating Tight pulse (Exterior Cold)?
3. A patient has a Slippery, Rapid pulse in the Left Guan position. What pattern(s) should you consider first?
4. What makes Regularly Intermittent (代 Dài) the most serious of the three irregular rhythm pulses?
5. Name two pulses that are normal findings in certain contexts (not always pathological).
6. What is the key difference between feeling for pulse depth at three levels vs. just noting "deep" or "shallow"?
7. How does a Choppy pulse differ from a Thin pulse — and what underlying condition does each suggest?